Country Profile: Egypt

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 7
- Plurality religion: Sunni Islam
- Official language: Arabic
- Official religion: Islam
- Core group: Arab Sunni Muslims

Historical Background

Egypt emerged as a modern state following the end of British protectorate status in 1922, although full political sovereignty was only achieved after the Free Officers revolution in 1952.[1] Egypt gained temporary control over the Gaza Strip following the 1949 armistice agreement with Israel, maintaining military administration there until 1967, apart from a brief Israeli occupation during the 1956 Suez Crisis.[2] Egypt also held sovereignty over the Sinai Peninsula until both Gaza and Sinai were lost during the 1967 Six-Day War. While Gaza remained outside Egyptian control thereafter, Egypt regained the Sinai through the Camp David Accords, culminating in full Israeli withdrawal in 1982.[3]

In 1958, Egypt entered a brief political union with Syria, forming the United Arab Republic (UAR). The union dissolved in 1961 following a Syrian coup, though Egypt retained the UAR name until 1971.[4] In 2011, mass protests during the Arab Spring led to the ousting of long-time president Hosni Mubarak. The revolution triggered a turbulent transitional period, marked by contested elections, the brief presidency of Mohamed Morsi, and a military coup in 2013 that brought Abdel Fattah el-Sisi to power.[5]

[1] Encyclopaedia Britannica, 2025a.
[2] Encyclopaedia Brirannica, 2025b.
[3] CIA Factbook, 2025.
[4] Encyclopaedia Brittanica, 2025c.
[5] CIA Factbook, 2025.

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Groups

Reliable demographic data for minority groups in Egypt is limited. Official census results are highly contested and often exclude or undercount marginalized communities such as Nubians, Jews, and Doms. Only Coptic Christians are consistently tracked through the All Minorities At Risk dataset; for other groups, population figures have been retrospectively attributed using secondary sources that vary significantly and are difficult to verify. Known demographic shifts—such as the displacement of Bedouin or the post-1967 exodus of Jews—remain unquantified due to the small size and marginalization of the groups. These limitations mean that available estimates should be understood as approximations rather than precise counts.

- **Bedouin** constitute approximately 0.3% of the population.[6] They first arrived in the territory of modern day Egypt after the 13th century and were well established in the region by the 18th century.[7] They primarily speak Eastern Egyptian Bedawi Arabic but also use Standard Arabic.[8] Religiously, they follow Sunni Islam, the plurality religion of Egypt.[9] In Egypt, Bedouin communities encompass both the quintessential nomadic tribes—who follow seasonal migration routes with their herds—and the more settled Fellahin, whose livelihoods center on cultivating the land.[10]
- **Coptic Christians**, the minority group in Egypt, constitute approximately 8.8% of the population and are concentrated primarily in Upper Egypt.[11] Coptic Christians believe themselves to be the descendants of Egypt's ancient Pharaonic people, having been converted to Christianity in the 1st century.[12] They primarily speak Egyptian Arabic.[13]
- **Doms** are a racialized group that constitute approximately 0.3% of the population.[14] They are a historically marginalized group with unclear origins, though some claim Arab descent or West African migration, explaining their

[6] AMAR, 2018.
[7] Bailey, 1985.
[8] Joshua Project, 2025.
[9] Joshua Project, 2025.
[10] Joshua Project, 2025.
[11] AMAR, 2018; Minority Rights, 2023a.
[12] Minority Rights, 2023a.
[13] EPR-ED, 2021; Ethnologue, 2025.
[14] Parrs, 2017.

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internal division into Ghagar and Halebi subgroups.[15] They primarily speak Domari, a severely endangered language in Egypt, as many have shifted to Egyptian Arabic.[16] Religiously, Doms follow Sunni Islam.[17] They are spatially concentrated in the Ad Daqahliyah governorate, north of Cairo.[18]

- **Nubians** are a racialized group that constitute approximately 0.3% of the population. Nubians are the descendants of Nubian groups who, following Arab invasions in the 7th and 11th centuries, were partially displaced or culturally absorbed, adopting the Arabic language and Arab religion and customs.[19] The 1899 Condominium Agreement divided the population between Egypt and Sudan, with Lower Nubians finding themselves under direct Egyptian rule and separated from their kin to the south.[20] They are linguistically diverse and are primarily associated with Egyptian Arabic, Nobiin, and Mattokki.[21] They follow Sunni Islam[22] and are spatially concentrated primarily in Upper Egypt, the Western Desert, and the Upper Nile regions.[23]
- **Arab Sunni Muslims** are the core group of Egypt, making up around 86% of the population.[24] Egypt, as a key destination and transit country for Arab Sunni refugees and migrants across the region, experienced notable influxes of two Arab Sunni subgroups during the study period: Palestinians, who fled to Egypt following the 1948, 1956, and 1967 Arab-Israeli wars, and Syrians, whose numbers surged after the 2011 Syrian civil war.[25] Palestinians were initially supported by Egypt under pan-Arab and anti-Zionist policies, though this support diminished following Egypt's rapprochement with Israel after 1977.[26] Arab Sunnis primarily speak Egyptian Arabic and use Standard Arabic for education and administration.[27]

[15] von Kremer, 1864.
[16] Glottolog, n.d.
[17] Joshua Project, 2025.
[18] Joshua Project, 2025.
[19] Joshua Project, 2025.
[20] Minority Rights, 2023c.
[21] Ethnologue, 2025; Joshua Project, 2025.
[22] Joshua Project, 2025.
[23] Joshua Project, 2025; Minority Rights, 2023c.
[24] United States Department of State, 2022; AMAR, 2021; Human Rights Watch, 1994.
[25] UNHCR, n.d.
[26] Tsourapas, 2018.
[27] EPR-ED, 2021.

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- **Arab Shia Muslims** are a minority group that constitute approximately 1% of the population. They are distinguished by their adherence to Shia Islam.[28] They primarily speak Egyptian Arabic and use Standard Arabic for education and official communication.[29]
- **Jews** were a minority group of that made up approximately 1% of the population in the 1940s, which decreased over time until their mass emigration in 1967.[30] By some estimates there were fewer than 200 self-identifying Jews in Egypt after 1967.[31] Egyptian Jews were adversely affected by the breakdown of Arab-Israeli relations after the establishment of the state of Israel in 1948. This encouraged outbreaks of attacks against Egypt's Jewish population, and further repression and violence occurred during the 1956 Suez Crisis and the 1967 Six Day War, especially following Egypt's defeat by Israel. Egyptian Jews primarily speak Egyptian Arabic, but Hebrew is a language of their common ancestry. Religiously, they follow Judaism. From 1945 until their departure in 1967, Jews in Egypt were spatially concentrated in urban areas like Cairo and Alexandria.[32]

State Profile

Official Language

In Article 149 of Egypt's 1935 Constitutional framework, Arabic is designated the official language of the state.[33] This is affirmed in Article 3 of the 1956 Constitution,[34] Article 5 of the 1964 Constitution,[35] and Article 2 of the Constitutions of 1971, 2011, 2012, and 2014.[36]

[28] Minority Rights, 2023d.
[29] Minority Rights, 2023d.
[30] Minority Rights, 2023b.
[31] Minority Rights, 2023b.
[32] Minority Rights, 2023b.
[33] Royal Decree No. 42, 1923.
[34] Constitution of the Republic of Egypt, 1956.
[35] Constitution of the United Arab Republic, 1964.
[36] Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 1971; Interim Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 2011; Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 2012; Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 2014.

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Official Religion

In Article 149 of Egypt's 1935 Constitutional framework, Islam is designated as the official religion of the state.[37] This is affirmed in Article 3 of the 1956 Constitution,[38] Article 5 of the 1964 Constitution,[39] and Article 2 of the Constitutions of 1971, 2011, 2012, and 2014.[40] Starting from the 1971 Constitution, Sharia is also mentioned as the main source of legislation.

Education Policies

The education system in Egypt is primarily overseen by the Ministry of Education and Technical Education (MOETE). Primary education is free and compulsory for children aged 6 to 14, covering six years of primary education (grades 1–6), followed by three years of lower secondary or preparatory education (grades 7–9).[41] After this, higher secondary education is divided into three streams: general (3 years), technical (up to 5 years), and vocational. [42] While public education remains dominant, the **private** sector has expanded, especially in urban areas; however, international and domestic private schools were either closed or nationalized between 1956 and 1959 following the Suez Crisis.[43]

A parallel system of religious education is administered by Al-Azhar, one of the oldest Islamic institutions globally. The Al-Azhar education system runs from primary to tertiary levels, following a curriculum that blends general education with religious instruction. This system is state funded but operates independently from the MOETE. It enrolls about 10% of the student population, offering an alternative yet nationally recognized certification.[44]

Language Education Policies

As late as the 1940s, foreign languages like **English** and **French** were still the primary means of instruction in the education system (not including Al-Azhar schools). A turning

[37] Royal Decree No. 42, 1923.

[38] Constitution of the Republic of Egypt, 1956.

[39] Constitution of the United Arab Republic, 1964.

[40] Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 1971; Interim Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 2011; Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 2012; Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 2014.

[41] Scholaro, n.d; Krafft et al., 2019.

[42] Scholaro, n.d.

[43] Laskier, 1995; Barda, 2006.

[44] Scholaro, n.d.

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point came in the early 1940s as schools switched to **Standard Arabic**, making Arabic the exclusive language of instruction in all public schools, while foreign-language schools continued to operate in English or French. Following the Suez Crisis of 1956, the state closed or nationalized most **French** and **English** schools. These actions formed part of a broader campaign of "Egyptianization" under Nasser, during which Arabic was made compulsory in the remaining institutions, and foreign curricula were suppressed.[45] Beginning in 1960, Egypt's language education policy began allowing for the gradual reintroduction of foreign-language classes. In regular public schools, all subjects are taught in Arabic, with English (and sometimes French) offered as foreign language subjects, typically starting in preparatory or secondary school.

In 1985, "experimental", or *tagreebi* schools (later renamed "public language schools" in 2014) were introduced. These schools offer instruction in English or French, or in core subjects like mathematics and science, while maintaining the national curriculum and teaching Arabic, religion, and civics in Arabic.[46] These schools are semi-public in nature due to moderate tuition fees and limited enrollment.[47]

Egypt does not incorporate minority or heritage languages (such as **Nobiin**, **Domari**, **Mattokki**, or **Hebrew**) into its public or private school systems either as mediums of instruction or as language subjects. These languages remain absent from formal curricula nationwide.

Religious Education Policies

Religious instruction in Egypt is mandatory in all schools that follow the national curriculum, including public, private, and international schools. Students are taught religion based on the affiliation listed on their official identity cards: either **Sunni Islam** or **Christianity**, specifically **Coptic Orthodox**.[48] Although there is no *de jure* provision explicitly prohibiting the teaching of other religions, like Judaism, in practice, such instruction does not occur.[49] Parents and students cannot opt out of religious teaching, and students not listed as Muslim or Christian must still choose one of the two religions. Islamic education is taught to Muslim students by graduates of Al-Azhar University, who typically hold advanced degrees. In contrast, Christian religious education is treated as a

[45] Barda, 2006.
[46] Krafft et al., 2019; United States Commission on International Religious Freedom, 2022.
[47] Krafft et al., 2019.
[48] Ha, 2016.
[49] United States Commission on International Religious Freedom, 2022.

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secondary subject.[50] The curriculum in Arabic language classes and other subjects also includes Islamic references and Qur'anic texts.

Al-Azhar's nationwide school system also provides religious instruction, and it provides more Islamic studies in its curriculum than the regular curriculum; it explicitly excludes any teaching about Shia Islam.[51] Although the state mandates that students should be taught their own religion, this only applies to Islam and Christianity.

Bans and Restrictions

Conversions and Proselytizing: Islam has been Egypt's official religion since 1923. In 1971, Islamic Sharia was adopted as a source of legislation, and in 1980, it was declared the main source of legislation. This marked the effective beginning of a state-level ban on apostasy.[52] While conversion to Islam is recognized, conversion from Islam is generally not, unless the individual was not born Muslim and obtains a court ruling.[53] Proselytizing is not explicitly prohibited, but non-Muslims face prosecution under blasphemy and public order laws. Christian proselytizers have been arrested and detained, while Islamic preaching is state supported.[54]

Shia Islam: Shia Islam is not officially recognized. Public Ashura commemorations are restricted, and the al-Hussein mosque is regularly closed to prevent Shia rituals. Between 1980 and 1990, under President Sadat and then Mubarak, the state intensified censorship and repression of Shia religious literature and speech. This was catalyzed by the Iranian Revolution, which sparked fears of Iranian influence. During this time, Shia publishing houses were shut down, foreign Shia students were arrested, and public dissemination of Shia beliefs was frequently criminalized as blasphemy or "insulting religion." The possession of Shia books was grounds for prosecution under public order charges, and public expressions of Shia belief could trigger criminal investigations.[55]

Coptic Orthodox Christianity: Church construction is restricted under laws dating back to 1856 and 1934. Until 2005, even repairs required presidential approval. Law 80/2016 was introduced to regulate construction but has been criticized for reinforcing

[50] Cook, 1999.
[51] Isaac, 2012; United States Commission on International Religious Freedom, 2022.
[52] Minority Rights, 2019.
[53] United States Department of State, 2021.
[54] Minority Rights, 2019; Human Rights Watch 1994; Gabbay, 2018.
[55] Minority Rights, 2019; United States Department of State, 2021.

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discrimination.[56] Violence against Copts, including the burning of churches, is frequent and often goes unpunished. Reconciliation sessions are used in place of judicial proceedings and often disadvantage Christians. During Sadat's presidency, Pope Shenouda III was exiled in 1980, and Coptic institutions were closed.[57]

Wearing of the Niqab. The niqab has been periodically banned in schools and universities since the late 1970s. The first wave of restrictions (1979–1988) began under President Anwar Sadat, who, in response to rising Islamist activism, banned Islamist student organizations and prohibited women from wearing the niqab on university campuses. The restriction was framed as necessary to maintain educational neutrality and public order, and was upheld by Egypt's Grand Mufti as compliant with Sharia. After Sadat's assassination in 1981, President Mubarak continued these policies under a state of emergency, reinforcing the regulation of religious symbols in public institutions. However, in 1988, the Administrative Court overturned the campus ban, ending the first period of formal prohibition. The second phase of restrictions resumed in 1994, when the Minister of Education issued a revised school uniform regulation. This forbade girls in primary schools from covering their hair and banned the niqab at all education levels. The policy allowed girls over age 12 to wear head coverings only with parental permission. The minister justified the regulation by arguing that education was slipping into the hands of religious extremists and needed to be reclaimed by the state.[58]

Demographic Engineering and Violence

Forced Relocations

Nubians: The construction of the Aswan High Dam in 1964 led to the forced displacement of approximately 50,000 to 55,000 **Nubians** from southern Egypt.[59] These communities were resettled in purpose-built settlements around Kom Ombo, far from their traditional Nile-based environment.[60] While Nubians have repeatedly demanded a return to areas closer to Old Nubia, their requests have been systematically denied. Presidential Decree 444 of 2014 designated much of the Lake Nasser littoral—where Nubians seek to return—as a restricted military zone, effectively blocking resettlement.[61]

[56] Minority Rights, 2019.
[57] Minority Rights, 2023a.
[58] Fenton, 2015; Droubi, 2012.
[59] Serag, 2013.
[60] Serag, 2013; Janmyr, 2016.
[61] Janmyr, 2016.

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Jews: Between 1956 and 1957, during the Suez Crisis, an estimated 20,200 to 25,000 **Jews** were expelled from Egypt.[62] During the 1956 and 1967 conflicts, Jewish individuals—including community leaders—were interned in camps such as Abu Zaabal and Tora.[63]

Bedouin: Between 2013 and 2015, Egyptian security forces demolished over 3,200 buildings and forcibly deported nearly 27,000 **Bedouin** people in North Sinai under the pretext of counterterrorism operations.[64] Operation Sinai 2018, launched in February of that year, resulted in the destruction of thousands more buildings and the displacement of an estimated 420,000 people.[65]

Constitutions and Laws

Egypt has had 10 constitutional frameworks throughout the study period. The first—the 1935 Revision of the 1923 Constitution—identified Islam as the official religion and Arabic as the official language in Article 149. It also recognized freedom of religion in Articles 12 and 13. The constitution makes no reference to any specific group.[66] Its successor, the interim 1953 Constitution, does not explicitly declare a state religion or language or mention any group; however, it maintains the recognition of freedom of religion in Article 4.[67]

Egypt adopted a new constitution in 1956, which explicitly mentions both **Arab Sunni Muslims** and **Arab Shia Muslims**. It reads: **"**We, the people of Egypt, realiz[e] that we form an organic part of a greater Arab entity." It reaffirms Islam and Arabic as the state religion and language in Article 3 and maintains the provision on the freedom of religion in Article 43.[68]

In 1958, Egypt and Syria joined to form the United Arab Republic, and an interim constitution was adopted in 1958. This constitution did not designate an official religion or language, nor did it explicitly recognize religious freedom, but it contained an explicit reference to the Arab nation.[69] A Constitutional Proclamation was made in 1962 after

[62] GSME, 2022; Laskier, 1986.
[63] Jewish Telegraphic Agency, 1956.
[64] Human Rights Watch, 2015; Görmüş, 2020.
[65] Minority Rights, 2023b.
[66] Royal Decree No. 43, 1923.
[67] Peaslee, 1956.
[68] Constitution of the Republic of Egypt, 1956.
[69] Provisional Constitution of the United Arab Republic, 1958.

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Syria left the union, keeping references to the Arab nation.[70] Another provisional constitution was declared in 1964, which formally reinstated Arabic and Islam as the official religion and language of the state in Article 5, as well as recognizing freedom of religion in Article 34.[71] General references to the Arab nation were kept.

When President Anwar Sadat took office in 1971, he adopted a new constitution, emphasizing a socialist Egypt and an Egyptian people as "part of the Arab nation" (Article 1). Article 2 reinforced Islam and Arabic as the official religion and language, and the provision on religious freedom was maintained.[72] Importantly, this Constitution proclaimed Sharia as a source of legislation, a provision which is still in force today. The 2011 interim Constitution, drafted during the Arab Spring, upheld these group provisions and maintained its mentions of "Arabs" (Articles 2, 46).[73]

As well as mentioning Arab peoples, the 2012 Constitution of Egypt mentions **Coptic Christians** and **Jews**: "The principles of Christian and Jewish laws are the main source of legislation for followers of Christianity and Judaism" (Article 3). Article 2 maintains the official status of Islam and Arabic. Religious freedom is not universally granted and only applies to "divine religions", which refers to (Sunni) Islam, Christianity, and Judaism.[74] After the Coup d'état in 2014, a new constitution was introduced, maintaining all previous provisions on Islam and Arabic, as well as enshrining religious freedom for Muslims, Christians, and Jews only.[75]

Citizenship Laws

Law 19/1929 established the principle of descent (Article 5), with limited *jus soli* provisions for children born in Egypt to foreign Muslim or Arabic-speaking fathers (Article 6[4]). Under Egypt's 1950 Nationality Law, the limited "double jus soli" provision that had granted automatic nationality to children born in Egypt to foreign fathers of Arabic-speaking or Muslim majority countries was expressly abolished. As a result, no child born in Egypt to foreign parents—regardless of their length of residence—acquired Egyptian nationality at birth, except for foundlings of unknown parentage.[76]

[70] Smith, 1970.
[71] Constitution of the United Arab Republic, 1964.
[72] Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 1971.
[73] Interim Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 2011.
[74] Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 2012.
[75] Constitution of the Arab Republic of Egypt, 2014.
[76] Malek, 2021; United Nations, 1954.

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A significant shift came with Law 391/1956, which introduced an explicit exclusion of "Zionists" from Egyptian nationality. While Jews were not formally barred, the conflation of Zionism with Judaism was common in public and administrative discourse.[77]

Law 82/1958 was enacted during the Egypt-Syria union and simply replaced the term "Egyptian" with "UAR." Despite the eventual dissolution of the union, the law remained in force for Egyptians until it was replaced in 1975. The current Law 26/1975 retains most earlier provisions, including the exclusion of Zionists (Article 1). Citizenship is automatically granted to those born to Egyptian fathers and, in some cases, to those born to Egyptian mothers if the father is stateless or unknown (Articles 2–3). Naturalization is possible for foreigners—particularly those of Arabic-speaking or Muslim backgrounds—provided they meet criteria relating to residency, character, and Arabic language proficiency (Article 4[3]).[78]

National Anthem(s)

In the study period, Egypt has had three national anthems. The first, "Salam Affandina", was instrumental with no official lyrics; it was used from 1871 to 1923 and then again from 1936 to 1958.[79] From 1961 to 1979, "Wallāh Zamān, Yā Silāḥī" was adopted. It opens with a direct reference to weapons as a symbol of liberation and national pride. The lyrics emphasize themes of popular struggle, martyrdom, and anti-imperial resistance—declaring the people's willingness to die for Egypt and portraying them as an unstoppable force, "like angry erupting volcanoes." Unlike monarchic or theocratic anthems in the region, it contains no religious references and instead elevates collective action, sacrifice, and sovereignty as the pillars of national identity.[80] Egypt's current national anthem, "Bilādī, Bilādī, Bilādī", is a patriotic hymn emphasizing love, loyalty, and national pride. Inspired by a speech by nationalist leader Mustafa Kamil, the anthem presents Egypt as the "mother of all lands" and a divine blessing to humanity, symbolized through the Nile. Unlike its predecessor, this anthem adopts a more lyrical and emotional tone, centering on affection rather than militarism. It contains no religious references or allusions to specific enemies, though it affirms the people's willingness to defend the

[77] Malek, 2021; Laskier, 1995.
[78] Malek, 2021.
[79] Nationalanthems.info, n.d.
[80] Nationalanthems.info, n.d.

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homeland in both "war and peace." The anthem projects unity, timelessness, and sovereignty, aligning with Egypt's post-war desire for stability and national dignity.[81]

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